

would melt a layer of powder in the shape of the object over which a new layer of powder would be applied and melted again.

A fourth system of 3D printing was inspired by the way an inkjet printer works, Ely Sachs and Mike Cima from MIT developed a system known as Binder Jetting. Here the raw material presented in a powder form is stuck together, layer by layer that is jetted on to the powder.

The advantage SLS has over FDM is the fact that any substances that can be released in a powder form can be used as raw material for printing. When you add to this the fact that the quality of finish one can expect from an SLS printer is far better than what one can expect from an FDM printer, it only sweetens the deal. Finally, the icing on this cake is the fact that the patent for SLS 3D printing expired in January 2014, many experts say that the 3D printing industry just might see a second revolution.

Add to that the fact that more major patents would expire over the course of the year, 3D printing is well on its way towards becoming an industry in its own right and has come a long way from industrial use to finding a place on our desks. Let's find out what happened along the way.



Is this the future of 3D printing?

So what happened along the way?

The 80s may have been the decade when the 3D printer was invented, the world didn't really get a chance to take a bite till about the early 90s when Charles Hull's company 3D Systems produced the first SLA printer that enabled the manufacture of prototype parts overnight.

While along the way, several companies including apple began to use 3D printers for make prototypes and companies like Hull's 3D Systems continued to develop the 3D printer, the real action began towards the end of the 90s when in 1999, scientists at the Wake Forest Institute for Regenerative Medicine used a 3D synthetic scaffold coated with the patient's cells. The cells are allowed to grow and the organ is transplanted in to the patient's body. As the cells are entirely the patient's the chances of the organ being rejected by the body are significantly reduced. While the organ may